

have identified two different aspects of cognitive dissonance that pertain to decision making.

1. *Selective perception.* Subjects suffering from selective perception register only information that appears to affirm a chosen course, thus producing a view of reality that is incomplete and, hence, inaccurate. Unable to objectively understand available evidence, people become increasingly prone to subsequent miscalculations.
2. *Selective decision making.* Selective decision making usually occurs when commitment to an original decision course is high. Selective decision making rationalizes actions that enable a person to adhere to that course, even if at an exorbitant economic cost. Selective decision makers might, for example, continue to invest in a project whose prospects have soured in order to avoid “wasting” the balance of previously sunk funds. Many studies show that people will subjectively reinforce decisions or commitments they have already made.

PRACTICAL APPLICATION

Example of Cognitive Dissonance

Smoking is a classic example of cognitive dissonance. Although it is widely accepted by the general public that cigarettes cause lung cancer and heart disease, virtually everyone who smokes wants to live a long and healthy life. In terms of cognitive dissonance theory, the desire to live a long life is dissonant with the activity of doing something that will most likely shorten one's life. The tension produced by these contradictory ideas can be reduced by denying the evidence of lung cancer and heart disease or justifying one's smoking because it reduces stress or provides a similar benefit. A smoker might rationalize his or her behavior by believing that only a few smokers become ill (it won't be me), that it only happens to two-pack-a-day smokers, or that if smoking does not kill them, something else will. While chemical addiction may operate in addition to cognitive dissonance for existing smokers, new smokers may exhibit a simpler case of the latter.

This case of dissonance could also be interpreted in terms of a threat to the self-concept.¹ The thought, “I am increasing my risk of lung cancer,” is dissonant with the self-related belief, “I am a smart, reasonable person who makes good decisions.” Because it is often easier to make excuses than it is